When the time came to find a chairman for Tata Sons, there were many things that Ratan's detractors faulted him for. They ran him down, stating that he had no proven capability and had not occupied any important position in the group. To them, his tenures with NELCO and Empress Mills did not bring him any laurels either. He was also criticized for not being able to handle the TELCO strike. His critics said that after he was appointed as the chairman of the second-largest company of the group, it spun dangerously out of control, plunging it deeper into a labour crisis.

The truth was, however, different. Despite the fact that he was given two failing enterprises, Ratan resurrected them. He took over NELCO and gave it a new lease of life. And by 1981, under his stewardship, the Empress Mills had also wiped out its losses, made profits and begun paying dividends. And when it came to TELCO, Ratan inherited a volcano of accumulated grievances of workers waiting to erupt due to years of neglect. In reality, much of the criticisms against Ratan were devoid of truth. A leading business journal opined, 'the negative side of Ratan Tata's ledger' was 'more apparent than real'.

JRD's decision to step down was hastened by his deteriorating health. From the beginning of 1991, his health had taken a turn for the worse. On 4 January, he had fallen ill in office. It was suspected that he had had a mild stroke. But he continued with his punishing schedule, even caring to visit R.M. Lala when he was hospitalized. At the end of February, he experienced further pain in his chest but kept it hidden, lest his doctors prevent him from going to Jamshedpur for the TISCO Founder's Day celebrations in early March.

In the steel city, he was once again taken ill but continued with his gruelling programme, even standing for an hour to deliver his speech. He returned to Bombay and was admitted to the Breach Candy Hospital on 10 March. Ratan briefed him almost every day on the affairs of the conglomerate. Ratan was by then chairman of eight entities, including TIL and TELCO, deputy or vice chairman of five companies, including TISCO and Tata Chemicals, and on the board of at least thirteen companies.

After six days, JRD returned home. On the following Monday, he was back in the office. But he knew it was time for him to hand over the reins. On the same day, Ratan was summoned to JRD's office. JRD asked him, 'What's new?' to which a perplexed Ratan replied that there was nothing, as he had been informing the chairman of everything. JRD then said: 'In that